
The Year of Your Mid-Back

Companion Workbook — map your mid-back's
patterns and track your progress

NATE RATCLIFF, LMT

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HEALING HANDS BY NATE

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Inner Circle Deep Cut — #3 Workbook

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Published by Healing Hands By Nate

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Introduction

A YEAR-LONG COMPANION TO THE IC3 DEEP CUT.
Map your mid-back's patterns and track your progress.

CHAPTER 1

How to use this workbook

YEAR-LONG REFERENCE. PATTERN SELF-ASSESSMENT when something flares. 30-day tracker when starting new practice. Seasonal check-ins.

Bring it to every session.

CHAPTER 2

Pattern Self-Assessment

Mobility Self-Tests (do these before answering questions)

TEST 1 — ROTATION. STAND. CROSS ARMS OVER chest. Without moving hips, rotate slowly to right as far as comfortable. Can you see directly behind you?

- ☐ Yes, fully
- ☐ Halfway behind
- ☐ Just over my shoulder
- ☐ Barely past my front shoulder

Switch to left. ☐ Same / ☐ Less / ☐ More than right

Test 2 — Extension. Stand tall. Hands on hips. Gently arch backward. Where do you feel the bend?

- ☐ Mid-back (between shoulder blades)
- ☐ Low back only
- ☐ Neck only
- ☐ Don't feel any bend

Test 3 — Breathing. Place one hand on chest, one on belly. Take a deep breath without changing anything else.

- ☐ Only belly moves (healthy)
- ☐ Both chest and belly
- ☐ Mostly chest
- ☐ Shoulders rise with breath

Right now, my mid-back feels:

Pain level (0-10): [____]

Where exactly?

- ☐ Both sides equally
- ☐ One side only — ☐ Right / ☐ Left
- ☐ Specific localized spot
- ☐ Wraps around to front (could indicate intercostal or shingles — see doctor)

Pattern questions

1. What feels most restricted?

- ☐ Extension (arching backward) → Pattern 1 (Desk Flexion Lock)
- ☐ Rotation → Pattern 2 (Tight Lats) or Pattern 1
- ☐ Breathing depth → Pattern 3 (Breathing Dysfunction)
- ☐ One-sided asymmetric → Pattern 4 (Asymmetry) or Pattern 5 (Old Trauma)

2. When does it bother me most?

- [] Through the workday → Pattern 1
- [] During overhead reaching → Pattern 2
- [] During emotional moments → Pattern 3
- [] One specific spot regardless of position → Pattern 5

3. Have I had any old injuries to the upper body, ribs, or mid-back?

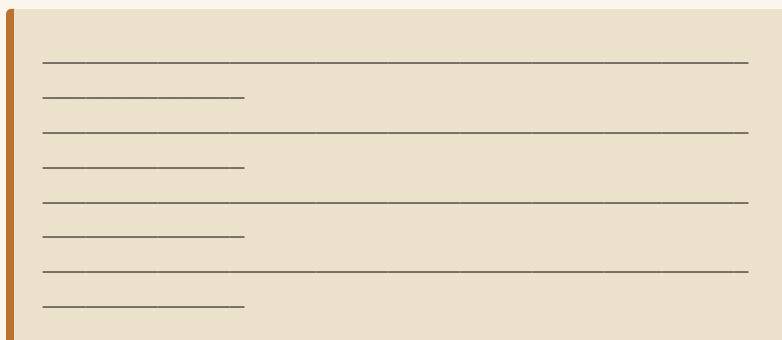
4. My best guess at the pattern:

5. Specific intervention I'll try first:

CHAPTER 3

Reflection Prompts

PROMPT 1: DESCRIBE WHAT YOUR POSTURE looks like at the end of a long workday. Be honest. Shoulders forward, head jutting? Chest collapsed? Take a moment to actually look in the mirror at end-of-day.

A writing area consisting of eight horizontal lines on a light beige background. A vertical brown line is on the left side of the area.

Prompt 2: When was the last time you took a really deep breath — one that fully expanded your rib cage? What were you doing? What was different about that moment?

Prompt 3: The mid-back is “where your body stores everything it can’t process.” What might yours be carrying? Old grief? Unspoken words? Held emotion? Be honest with yourself.

CHAPTER 4

30-Day Mid-Back Tracker

Daily check pattern

- Did I do the daily routine? (Y/N)
 - Open-book stretch specifically (Y/N)
 - Breathing depth at midday (1 = shallow, 10 = full)
 - Mid-back restriction right now (1 = none, 10 = severe)
 - One word
-

Week 1

DAY	DATE	ROUTINE?	OPEN-BOOK?	BREATH (1-10)	RE-STRIC-TION	ONE WORD
1						
2						
3						
4						
5						
6						
7						

Week 2

DAY	DATE	ROUTINE?	OPEN-BOOK?	BREATH (1-10)	RE-STRIC-TION	ONE WORD
8						
9						
10						
11						
12						
13						
14						

Week 3

DAY	DATE	ROUTINE?	OPEN-BOOK?	BREATH (1-10)	RE-STRIC-TION	ONE WORD
15						
16						
17						
18						
19						
20						
21						

Week 4

DAY	DATE	ROUTINE?	OPEN-BOOK?	BREATH (1-10)	RE-STRIC-TION	ONE WORD
22						
23						
24						
25						
26						
27						
28						
29						
30						

CHAPTER 5

30-Day Reflection

RE-DO THE THREE MOBILITY TESTS FROM THE beginning. Compare:

Rotation right: [] Fully behind / [] Halfway / [] Just over shoulder (Day 1: _) **Rotation left:** [] **Fully behind** / [] **Halfway** / [] **Just over shoulder** (Day 1: _) Extension: [] Mid-back bends now / [] Still low back only / [] Still neck only Breathing: [] Belly moves more / [] Same / [] Chest still dominant

Average restriction (Days 1-7 vs 24-30): _ → __

Number of days I did the routine: ____ out of 30

Did the open-book stretch specifically: ____ out of 30

What's the biggest change?

Did people comment on my posture changing?
[Yes / No]

What still needs work?

CHAPTER 6

Seasonal Check-Ins

Spring Check-In

DATE: ____

Mid-back coming out of winter (0-10 stiffness):
[__]

Pre-yard-work warm-up commitment: [] Yes / [] No

Summer Check-In

Date: ____

AC exposure hours/day: ____

Hot shower on mid-back nightly? [] Yes / [] No

Fall Check-In

Date: ____

Cumulative summer load on mid-back (0-10):
[__]

Fall recovery commitment:

Winter Check-In

Date: __

Morning mid-back stiffness (0-10): [__]

Daily routine consistency this winter so far: []

Daily / [] Most days / [] Inconsistent

CHAPTER 7

Year-End Mid-Back Inventory

COMPARED TO JANUARY, MY MID-BACK IS: ☐ Better / ☐ Same / ☐ Worse

Breathing depth: ☐ Better / ☐ Same / ☐ Worse

Posture (other people noticing): ☐ Better / ☐ No comments / ☐ Worse

Range of motion (rotation, extension): ☐ Better / ☐ Same / ☐ Worse

One thing I'll commit to for next year:

CHAPTER 8

Try this for 30 days

IF YOU DO NOTHING ELSE FROM THIS WORKBOOK, try this:

Open-book stretch. 5 reps each side. Twice a day. Every day for 30 days.

That's 4 minutes a day total. Two short sessions.

The mid-back is the area that responds fastest to consistent attention. Most people see real, structural change in 30 days with this one stretch alone — better breathing, easier posture, less neck and shoulder tension as downstream benefits.

Bring this workbook to your next session.

— Nate



This book was crafted by Nate Ratcliff,
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